CS × X: Computing that creates value for Ashoka and the world

VSAC's strength in computer science, multiplied by Ashoka's liberal arts, applied in the contexts that matter to India and the world, through mechanisms that turn research into impact.

A tentative, outside-in view. This framework draws on conversations with Ashoka and on secondary research, mainly Ashoka's public pages on VSAC, its centres and faculty. It has not drawn on internal plans. Thematic areas, mechanisms, stakeholders and KPI targets are indicative; some facts may be incomplete or out of date. Interactive version: misralakshmi.github.io/vsac-strategy

VSAC'S VISION

"Exploring and Harvesting the Future of Computing for Sustainable Human Progress"

Explore at the frontier · harvest value through strategic utilisation · stay anchored in ethical responsibility · serve humanity. CS × X is how VSAC delivers the second principle.

POSITIONING

India's school for responsible computing and AI: **technical rigour with human purpose.**

CS

The core

Vachani School of Advanced Computing.

Academic units

DEPARTMENTS

- Computer Science
- Data Science & AI

CENTRES AND LABS

- Digitalisation, AI & Society
- Koita Centre for Digital Health
- Safexpress CDLDS
- Data Science & Analytics
- Maker Space · Mphasis AI Lab

Areas of work INDICATIVE

- AI & machine intelligence
- Data science & decisions
- Security, privacy & crypto
- Systems, quantum & hardware
- Human-centred computing

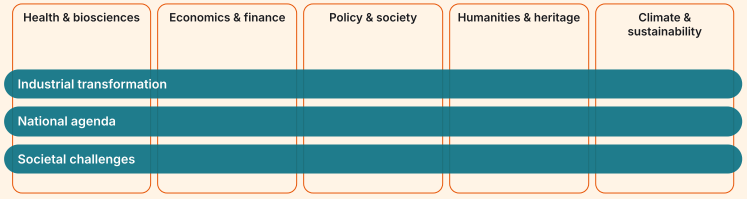
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X

The liberal arts

Ashoka's humanities, social sciences and sciences. X is what makes VSAC different: computing shaped by ethics, society and human judgement, not computing alone.

The liberal arts, in the contexts VSAC works in INDICATIVE



Horizontal: the contexts in which VSAC operates Vertical: the liberal arts (X)

Through mechanisms INDICATIVE

- Experimental spaces
- Incubation
- Technology transfer
- Joint research
- Research Park

Led with Ashoka's schools and centres: Humanities, Economics and Finance, Biosciences, Public Policy, Social and Behaviour Change, Management.

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Value

For partners

Innovation and AI transformation, public and societal impact, research partnerships and talent.

For Ashoka

Funding, reputation, government relationships, scale, and knowledge: IP and papers.

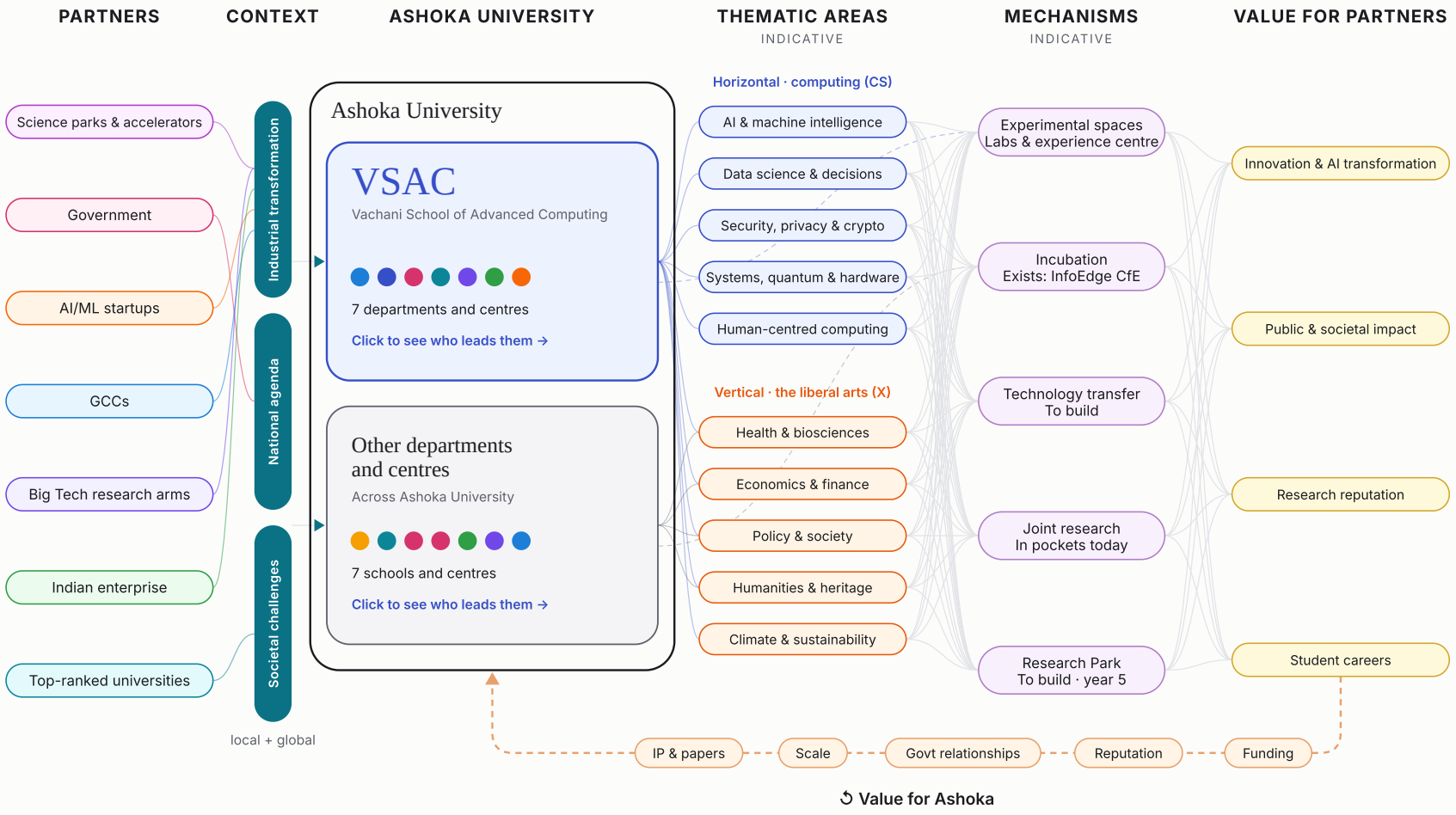
Funded through the founding gift, industry affiliates, sponsored research and named labs, government missions, CSR and philanthropy, and paid programmes.

↻ **Feedback loop** Value flows back to shape what CS at Ashoka becomes: its courses, research agenda and hiring.

OPERATING MAP

How CS × X works in practice

VSAC operates in three contexts: industrial transformation, the national agenda and societal challenges. Partners in each bring work that Ashoka's units take on across computing and the liberal arts, and a set of mechanisms turns the work into value for partners and for Ashoka.



HOW TO READ IT

From context to value

LEFT TO RIGHT

VSAC operates in three contexts: industrial transformation, the national agenda and societal challenges. Seven kinds of partners in those contexts bring work to VSAC. Inside Ashoka University, VSAC works them with the university's other departments and centres, across computing and the liberal arts, through a set of mechanisms, into value for partners.

UNDERNEATH

Value for Ashoka: funding, reputation, government relationships, scale and IP.

TRY

Trace a partner above, click VSAC or Other departments and centres to see who leads them, or click any theme or mechanism.

MECHANISMS AND SEQUENCE

02

Build on what exists, add what is missing

Incubation and experimental spaces already have a home at Ashoka, and joint research exists in pockets. Technology transfer and the Research Park need building, the park last.

Year 1
Open the front door

Experimental spaces · Technology transfer set-up · Joint research

Year 3
Convert demand into deals

Deep-tech incubation track · First licences and contracts

Year 5
Build the park

Research Park with committed anchor tenants

SEED EXISTS

Experimental spaces

Labs, makerspaces and an experience centre: places where faculty, students and partners build and test together.

AT ASHOKA TODAY

Mphasis AI & Applied Tech Lab, its Digital Makerspace, and centre labs such as KCDH-A and CDLDS.

EXISTS

Incubation

AT ASHOKA TODAY

InfoEdge Centre for Entrepreneurship, 100+ startups. Add a deep-tech AI track with VSAC faculty.

BUILD

Technology transfer

AT ASHOKA TODAY

To build: IP policy, licensing and sponsored-research contracts for VSAC.

IN POCKETS

Joint research and exchange

AT ASHOKA TODAY

Board of Advisors from IIT Kharagpur, ISI Kolkata, MIT and Google DeepMind; KCDH-A's India–Singapore grant.

BUILD

Research Park

AT ASHOKA TODAY

To build by year five, with anchor tenants committed first.

POTENTIAL STAKEHOLDERS

Who VSAC should work with, and how

Named organisations by partner type, mapped to the thematic areas and mechanisms where they fit. Solid badges mark ties Ashoka already has; the rest are prospects to approach.

HOW PARTNERS CONNECT

VSAC Industry Advisory Council

An advisory council of 12 to 15 senior leaders that connects VSAC's teaching and research to industry, opens doors to partners and builds a lasting funding base. It complements the academic Board of Advisors.

Partnerships
introductions and real problem statements

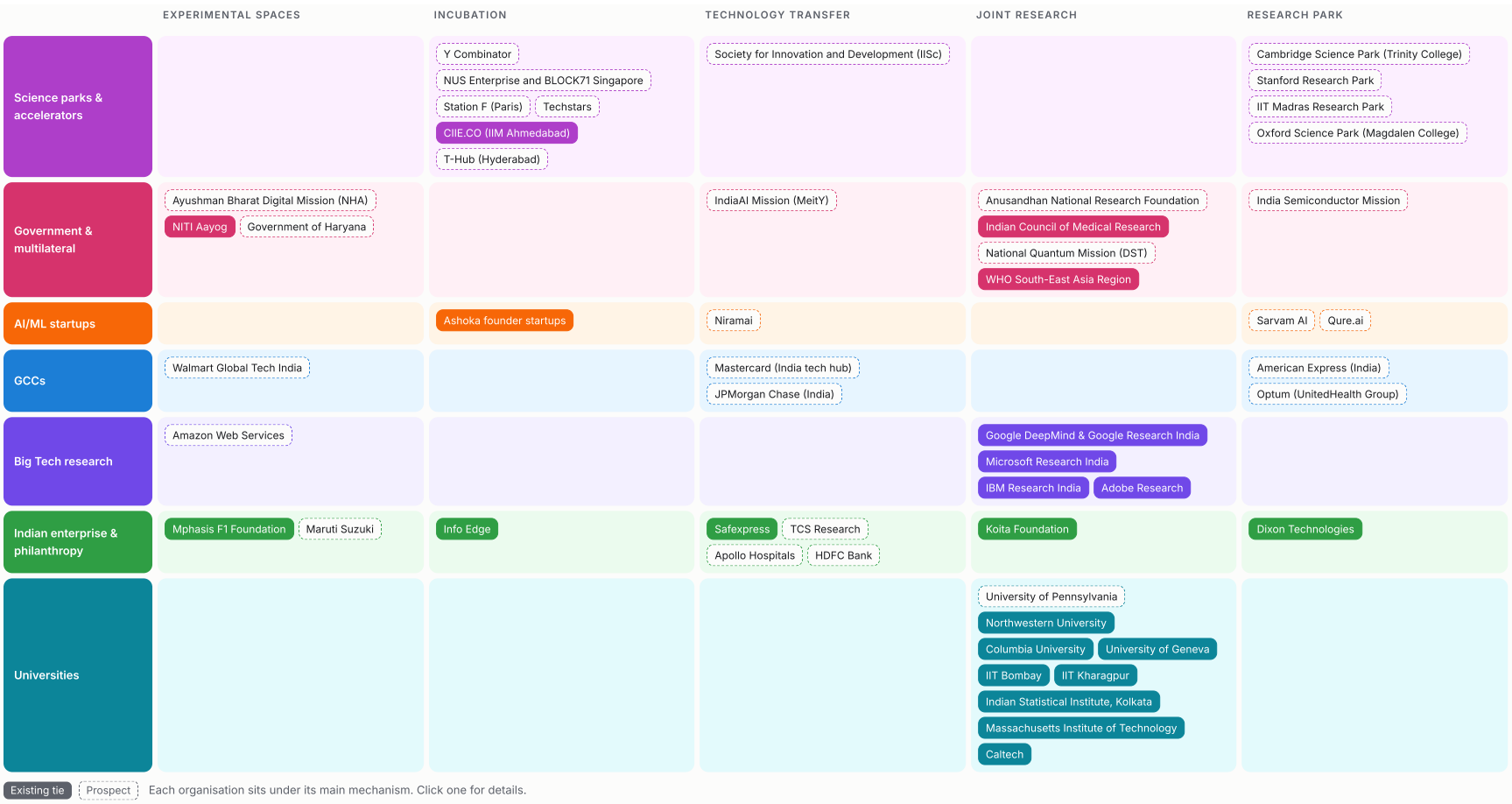
Talent
curriculum review, internships, mentoring

Funding
affiliates, named labs, chairs and scholarships

Seats: founding and named-centre funders · global technology companies · Indian enterprises · startups and investors · public sector and industry bodies · a bridge member from the Board of Advisors. Meets three times a year.

11	9	4	5	5	9	9
Science parks & accelerators	Government & multilateral	AI/ML startups	GCCs	Big Tech research	Indian enterprise & philanthropy	Universities

52 organisations shown · 22 existing ties · 30 prospects



HOW TO READ IT

52 organisations, seven partner types

Rows are partner types; columns are the mechanism each would mainly work through. Solid chips are ties Ashoka already has; dashed chips are prospects.

TRY

Click any organisation, or filter by area, mechanism or status above.

KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATORS · YEARS 1, 3 AND 5

What success looks like by year five

Six groups of indicators that follow the map: four for value for partners (innovation and AI transformation, public and societal impact, research reputation, student careers), one for the mechanisms, and value for Ashoka.

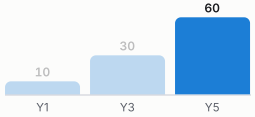
Proposed targets for discussion. Baselines are set in the first 90 days; the numbers below show the intended scale and slope, and are revised once baselines are known.

Innovation and AI transformation

The main value VSAC creates for its partners

Partner problems solved together

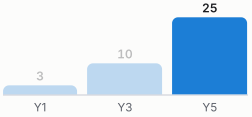
60 Year 5



Co-developed by faculty and students

AI solutions adopted by partners

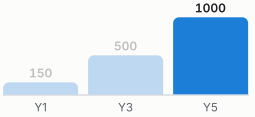
25 Year 5



Prototypes partners put into real use

Professionals upskilled in AI

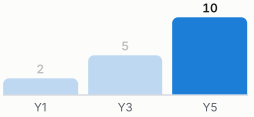
1000 Year 5



Executive education and sessions in experimental spaces

Innovation programmes run with partners

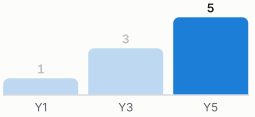
10 Year 5



Challenges, studios and hackathons

Science park and accelerator links

5 Year 5



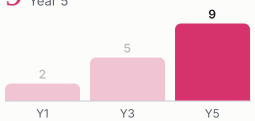
e.g. Cambridge, IIT Madras, Y Combinator

Public and societal impact

Work that serves India's missions and society

Government-funded projects

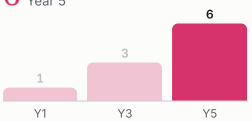
9 Year 5



Active in the year

Pilots in public systems

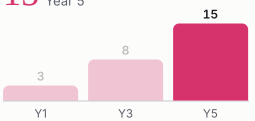
6 Year 5



Running with a government partner

Societal challenge projects

15 Year 5



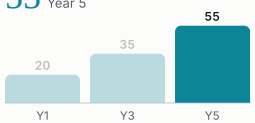
With NGOs, public bodies and communities

Research reputation

Standing with global peers

Papers at top-tier venues

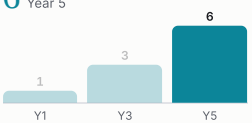
55 Year 5



Per year, VSAC faculty and students

Joint grants with global partners

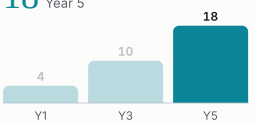
6 Year 5



Cumulative

Visiting faculty and exchanges

18 Year 5



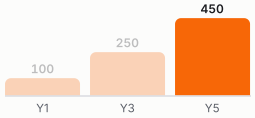
Per year

Student careers

Partners shaping talent

Students on partner-sponsored projects

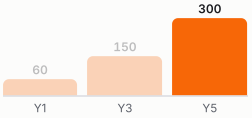
450 Year 5



Capstones, challenges and studios

Internships through partners

300 Year 5



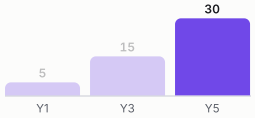
Per year

Mechanisms: translation

How research turns into products, deals and ventures

Invention disclosures

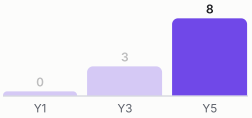
30 Year 5



Filed with the technology-transfer office

Licences and tech-transfer deals

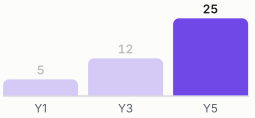
8 Year 5



Signed agreements

VSAC-linked startups incubated

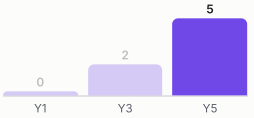
25 Year 5



With the InfoEdge Centre for Entrepreneurship

Research Park anchor tenants

5 Year 5



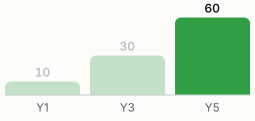
Signed before the park is built

Value for Ashoka

What flows back to the university: the founding gift builds capacity, recurring sources fund operations

External funding raised

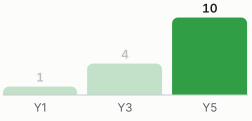
60 ₹ crore · Year 5



Grants and sponsored research, per year

Recurring industry revenue

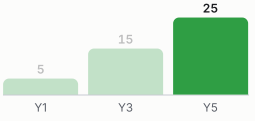
10 ₹ crore · Year 5



Executive education and sponsored projects

Non-philanthropic share of VSAC budget

25% Year 5



Grants, contracts and fees